



SARAH M. SMART

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UX content designer/writer specializing in B2B, fintech, and SaaS

AI-augmented content workflows, terminology, critical communications, and more

AS SEEN AT



TONIGHT'S MENU

What's cooking

01 **From the test kitchen**

AI content systems and workflows

02 **Small plates**

A microcopy smorgasbord

03 **By the slice**

End-to-end case study · Shopify Payments

I don't use AI to write copy

I do use it to empower others to write quality content and to communicate ideas about UX in a more compelling way

Building an agentic terminology workflow

```
graph LR; A[Analyze competitors] --> B[Gather evidence]; B --> C[Assemble matrix]; C --> D[Apply documented conventions]; D --> E[Recommend with tradeoffs]; E --> F[Human review]
```

Analyze competitors → Gather evidence → Assemble matrix → Apply documented conventions → Recommend with tradeoffs → Human review

PROBLEM

People doing UX writing needed terminology guardrails and guidance after UserTesting acquired UserZoom

CHALLENGES

- Terminology evidence lived in 5 places, not all of them well-socialized
- The design system lacked content guidance for components

Agentic terminology workflow

DECISIONS

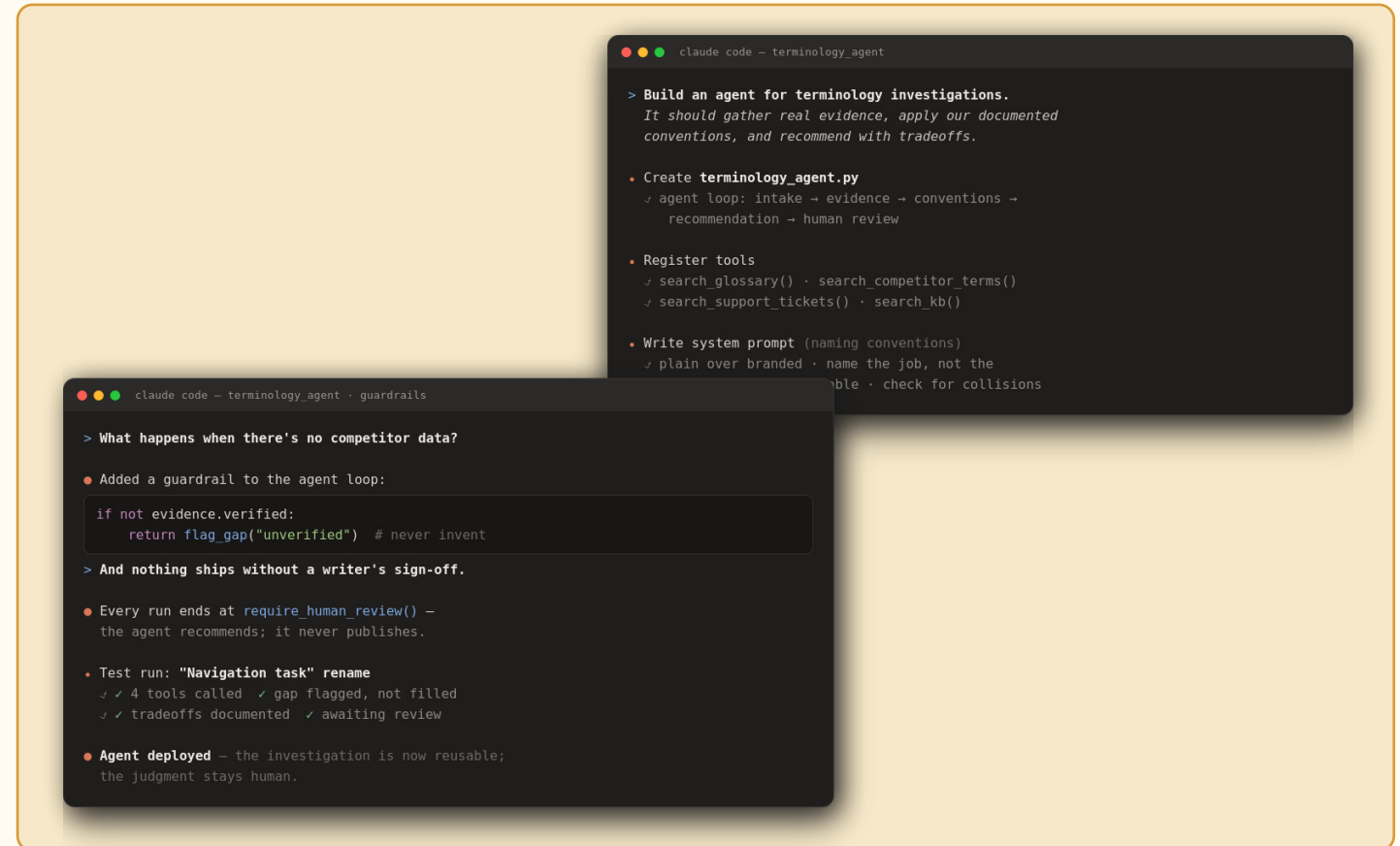
- Give AI more material to draw from
- Detail the principal-level multi-step terminology investigation
- Use if-then logic to prescribe different potential pieces of the output
- Turn a one-off exploration into a thorough, time-saving process

The image displays two side-by-side screenshots. On the left is a Google Sheet titled 'Core glossary' with columns for Term (en-US), Definition, Type, Do not use..., Term appears..., In-app customer-facing?, and In-app participant-facing?. It lists various testing-related terms like 'Testing', 'Menu navigation (pages)', 'Audience', 'Test builder', 'Monitor', 'Results', 'Review', 'Setup', 'Test types & devices', 'Unmoderated test', 'Think-out loud test', and 'Interaction test'. On the right is a Mosaic design system page for 'Popovers'. It includes a definition: 'Displays contextual information or actions in a floating layer triggered by user interaction.' It also features 'Writing tips' (e.g., 'Use when content is too long or complex for a tooltip'), 'Do and don'ts' (e.g., 'Balanced comparison', 'Reduce bias'), and 'Prototype tips' (e.g., 'Have the prototype in a separate file to minimize size').

Agentic terminology workflow

WHAT I DID

- Created content guidance for every design system component
- Consolidated and updated 3+ style guides with the team
- Defined process, competitors, research guidelines, other skills to use, and output



Agentic terminology workflow

WHAT AI DID

- Put together reports with screenshots from competitor sites
- Searched the updated design system for our product's current terms
- Built complete terminology tables to help sell the content vision of the project

```
claude code - terminology-workflow - evidence

> Investigate renaming the "Navigation task" step type

• Read core-glossary.csv (312 terms)
  ✓ "Navigation task" - noun · step type that sends participants to a URL

• Search competitor terminology (maze, lookback, userlytics, qualtrics)
  ✓ Maze: "Mission" · Userlytics: "Task / Scenario"
  ✓ Lookback: "Task" · Qualtrics: -

• Search support tickets: "navigation task"
  ✓ 14 tickets - customers expect prototype testing, find URL setup instead

⚠ No direct competitor precedent for "URL task" - flagging as unverified rather than inventing a match
```

```
claude code - terminology-workflow - recommendation

• Recommendation: "URL task"
  Covers both website and prototype URLs; follows glossary conventions - plain, descriptive, translatable.

Tradeoffs
├─ ✓ names the job, not the mechanics
├─ ✓ survives the classic → new migration
├─ ✗ collides with existing "Task" step type
├─ ✗ no competitor precedent (documented, not hidden)

Stopgap - subtitle bridge ships now, so customers get descriptive context while the rename survives debate.

- Queued for human review. Nothing ships until a writer approves.
```

Agentic terminology workflow

EXAMPLE OUTPUT

LOOKBACK

AI session synthesis and goals-based findings

Less about drafting tests, more about preserving context and evidence through qualitative work.

Eureka Headlines

Lookback uses AI to summarize sessions into Headlines and to connect suggested findings back to defined goals.

Frame the studyProbeAnalyze

KEY UI TERMS

1Headlines

2Time-stamped moments

USERLYTICS

Evidence-backed AI insights with visible provenance

A strong model for explainability and research-audit confidence.

AI Insights

AI-generated annotations

Userlytics exposes the data scope behind AI answers and shows where each insight came from.

Analyze

KEY UI TERMS

1Based on: Sessions / Transcriptions / Annotations

2Found on verification bar

3Ask any question

4AI-generated annotations

PATTERN TO NOTICE

The UI makes the AI answer feel grounded in study evidence rather than magical or opaque.

Provenance is visible in the workspace, which helps teams trust and audit what the model is surfacing.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR YOUR AI TEST BUILDER

Useful pattern for explaining why the AI generated a question or which inputs influenced it.

Could reduce reviewer anxiety by showing what evidence, examples, or templates shaped the output.

Source: official producthelp page screenshots

8

terminology audit						
UserTesting term	Part of speech	Definition	Maze	Lookback	Userlytics	Qualtrics
Template	Noun	A pre-built or user-created test plan that can be launched or customized, including tasks, questions, and audience criteria.	Template	-	Template	Survey template
Templates Library	Noun	A browsable collection of UT-authored templates organized by use case or method.	Template gallery	-	Template library	Catalog / Marketplace
Account template	Noun	A customer-created template scoped to their organization for internal reuse and standardization.	Custom template	-	Custom template	Library survey / Brand template
Personal template	Noun	A customer-created template scoped to one user.	Custom template	-	Custom template	-
UserTesting template	Noun	A UserTesting-authored template available to all customers via the Template Gallery.	Maze-made template	-	Pre-built template	Expert-designed template / Qualtrics template
Complete test	Noun	A template type that includes both a pre-configured test plan and a predefined audience, enabling launch with minimal setup.	Ready-to-go template	-	-	Guided project / Pre-built solution
	Noun	An AI-powered feature that generates a test plan from a description or goal.	AI-generated Maze	-	-	Build with AI / AI-assisted survey creation
	Noun	The full configuration of a study including tasks, questions, screens, and audience settings.	Maze (project)	Session guide / Research guide	Study / Study setup	Survey / Project
	Noun	The target participant group defined by demographics, behavior, or custom criteria.	Panel / Participants	Participants	Target audience / Panel	Distribution list / Panel / Audience
	Noun	An instruction given to a participant to perform a specific action during a study.	Mission / Block	Task	Task / Scenario	-
	Noun	A prompt presented to participants to gather qualitative or quantitative feedback.	Question block	Question	Question	Question
	Noun	A qualifying questionnaire used to filter participants before they enter a study.	Screener	Screener / Participant filter	Screening questions	Screening questions / Contact filters
	Noun	A narrative context or setup provided to participants before a task, describing the situation they should imagine themselves in.	-	-	Scenario	-

terms from competitors			
Part of speech	Source	Definition	
Noun	Maze	A modular, reusable unit within a test (e.g., question block, opinion scale block, task block). Blocks can be rearranged and combined to build studies.	
Noun	Maze	A task-based block where participants navigate a prototype to complete a specific goal. Analogous to a UT task but scoped to prototype testing.	
Noun	Maze	A sequence of screens or steps within a prototype that a participant is expected to navigate. Used to define success paths.	
Noun	Qualtrics	A centralized repository of pre-validated, reusable questions organized by topic or methodology. Users can search and insert individual questions into any survey.	
Noun	Qualtrics	An AI-powered feature that scores and critiques a draft survey for methodology issues, bias, and best practices before launch.	
Noun	Lookback	A structured script or outline used to guide a moderated research session. Includes prompts, questions, and timing notes.	

proposed terminology updates			
from	to	why	
Templates Library	Library	broader to encompass more use cases (like, does a saved question count as a template?), we avoid pairing ourselves into a corner here, and it's not that different from what we have today.	
task, question, instructions, task groups, task steps...	block	It's proven in market (used by Maze), and it's broad enough to encompass all the types of things you add to a test. it would be useful to have a term like this.	
UserTesting template	Designed by experts	we position ourselves ahead of competitors (and in line with Qualtrics), and we avoid having to explain the rigor and quality of these templates every time.	
account/workspace template	Shared	in line with other sharing paradigms (apple, google, e.g.), reinforces that the system and the user are in a dialog together, also hint to perspective about who is doing the sharing.	
personal templates	Saved	this could work for audiences and questions as well, and it avoids putting too much focus on the the user ("my templates"), UI ("your template"), or the noun included in here.	

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A modal

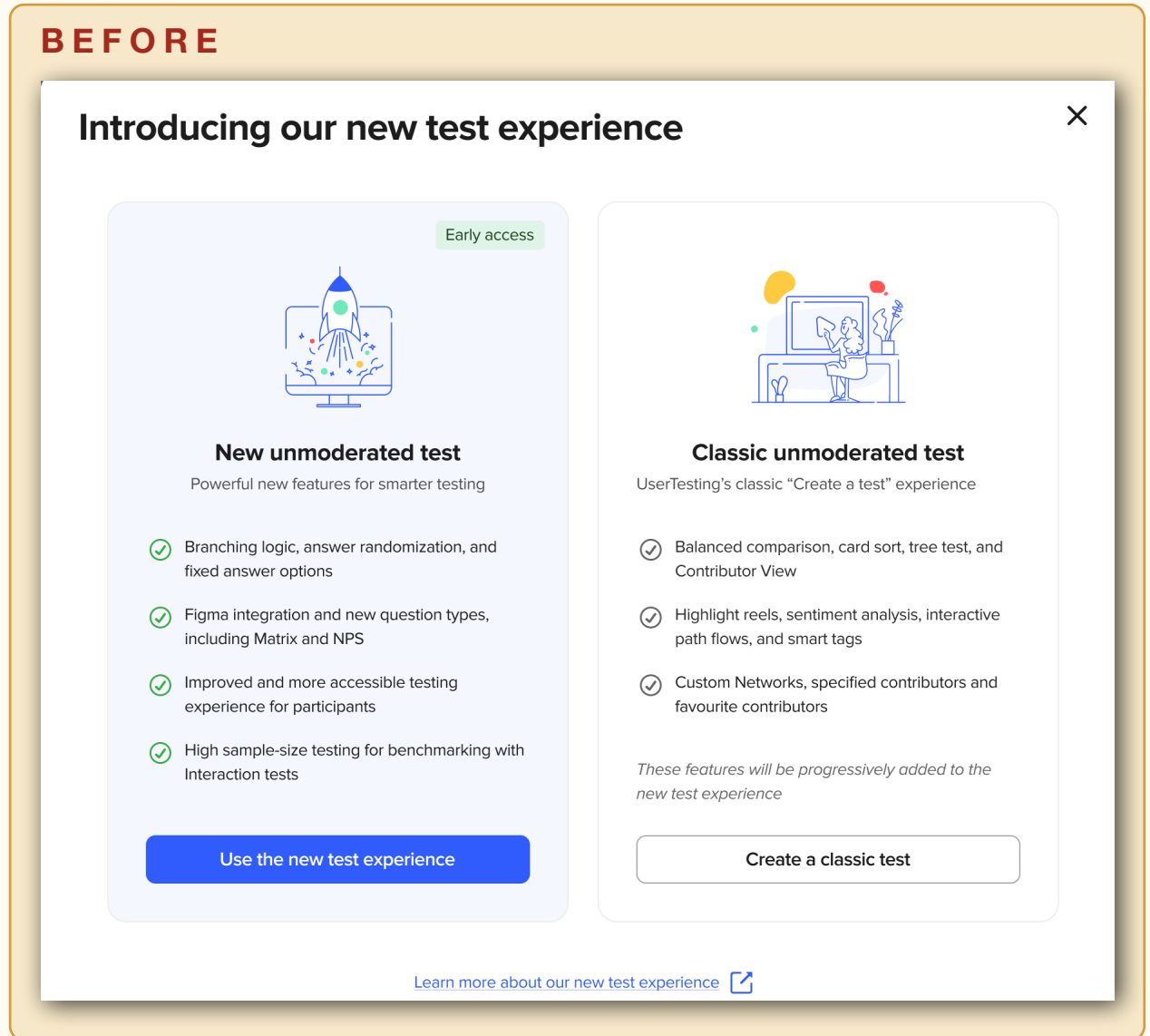
PROBLEM

As a customer, I want to understand whether I should use the new experience so that I can get the research insights I'm looking for

CONSTRAINTS

- Customers met the classic-or-new choice with no earlier signaling
- We couldn't yet prove “better” positioning

BEFORE



A modal

DECISIONS

- Center the new experience to reduce choices to one clear action
- Swap claims for concrete capabilities
- Provide clarity on what is and isn't available in the new experience

+63.1%

customers creating in the new experience over the old*

*in comparable research rounds

AFTER

New

Try our updated think-out-loud experience

We're rebuilding our unmoderated tests with new features to help you test better



Available now

-  Advanced test setup options for more control
-  Higher sample sizes for benchmarking
-  New question types for deeper insights
-  Access to AI-powered tools for faster analysis

[Learn more about our new test experience](#)

Coming soon

-  Card sorts and tree tests
-  Path visualizations
-  Favorite and specified participants

We'll let you know when features move to the new experience

Cancel

Create a test

A message sequence

PROBLEM

As a merchant, I want to learn when I get paid for my shop sales and understand why that might change so that I can make the right decisions

CONSTRAINTS

- Merchants had no consistent home for payout information
- Language needed to accommodate unannounced future business plans

BEFORE

Shopify Balance

Your payout speed has been upgraded
You'll now get paid faster for sales made with Shopify Payments. Payouts can arrive within an hour of your sales, during certain times. [Learn more](#)

Payouts

Previous payout: **\$4,962.34** (Paid) Apr 2, 2019
Next payout: **\$4,804.80** (Pending) Apr 3, 2019
Balance: **\$5,467.70** (Est. by Apr 16, 2019)

Payout date	Status	Charges	Refunds	Adjustments	Fees	Total
Apr 3, 2019	Pending	\$4,851.99	\$0.00	\$98.37	-\$145.56	\$4,804.80
Apr 2, 2019	Paid	\$5,872.87	-\$734.35	\$0.00	-\$176.19	\$4,962.34
Apr 1, 2019	Paid	\$9,225.35	-\$199.20	\$0.00	-\$276.76	\$8,749.39
Mar 31, 2019	Paid	\$3,644.86	-\$460.89	\$0.00	-\$109.35	\$3,074.62

A message sequence

DECISIONS

- Describe new concepts instead of naming them
- Give merchants a reason for every delay
- Pair a permanent home for payment settings with event-triggered banners

-18%

support tickets about
payout timing

AFTER

① At first, funds will be available 7 business days after transactions to help prevent fraud ×
[Learn more](#)

① You're approved for faster payouts ×
Funds for transactions **after {date}** will be available in 5 business days
[Learn more](#)

Payouts and transfers

How you get paid for your sales

Statement name

Shopify Payments

Transfers sent

monthly

On

the first Monday

☒ Get notified by email every time you receive a transfer

Funds are available 7 business days after transactions, not counting weekends and holidays. [Learn more](#)

Some errors

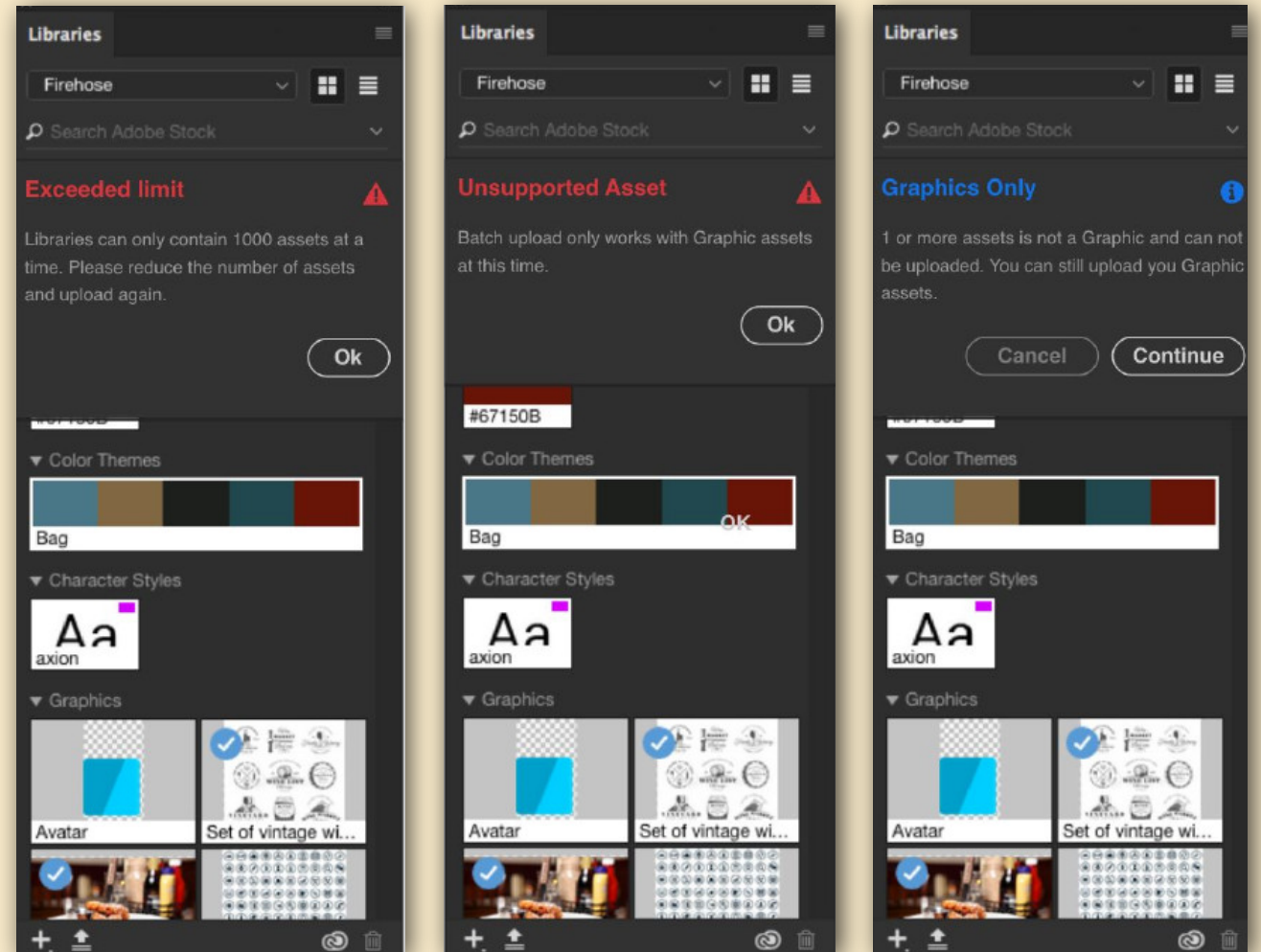
PROBLEM

As a creative pro managing different file types in Bridge, I want to know why a bulk upload failed so that I can fix it and move on with my life

CONSTRAINTS

- The tight panel space on mobile ruled out stacked messages
- Some use cases could be combined but not all

BEFORE



Some errors

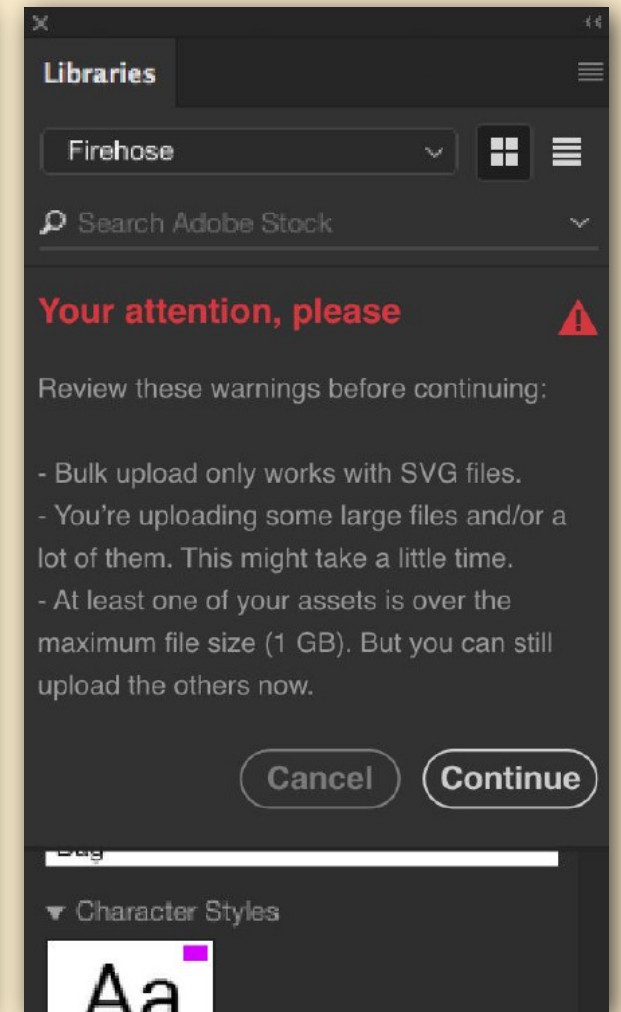
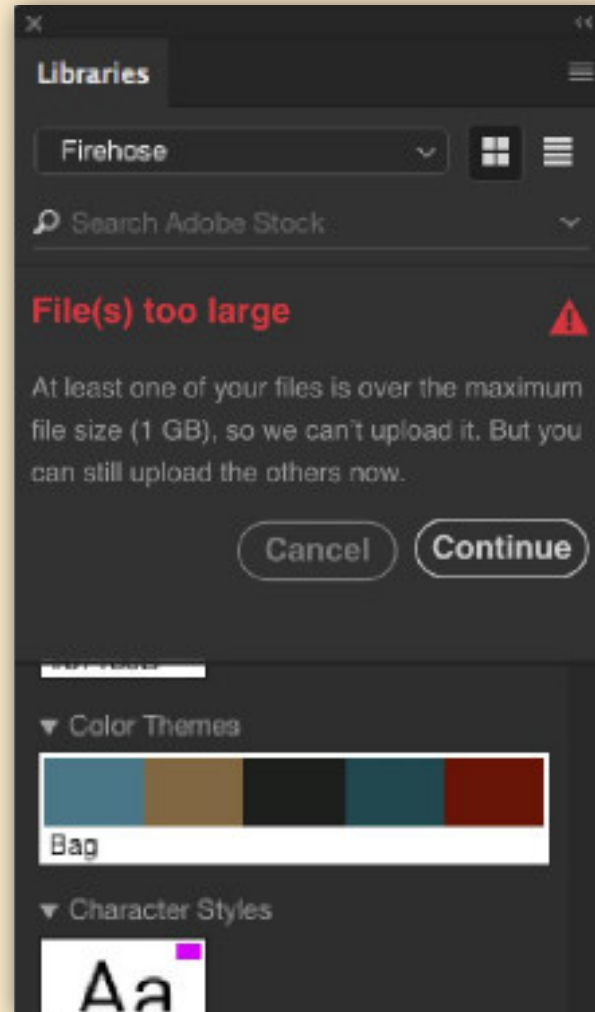
DECISIONS

- Deliberately break best practices for a more digestible user experience
- Distill and consolidate use cases to create a reusable matrix
- Evolve the voice and tone after decades of no UX writing practice

+14%

successful bulk upload completion after an error

AFTER



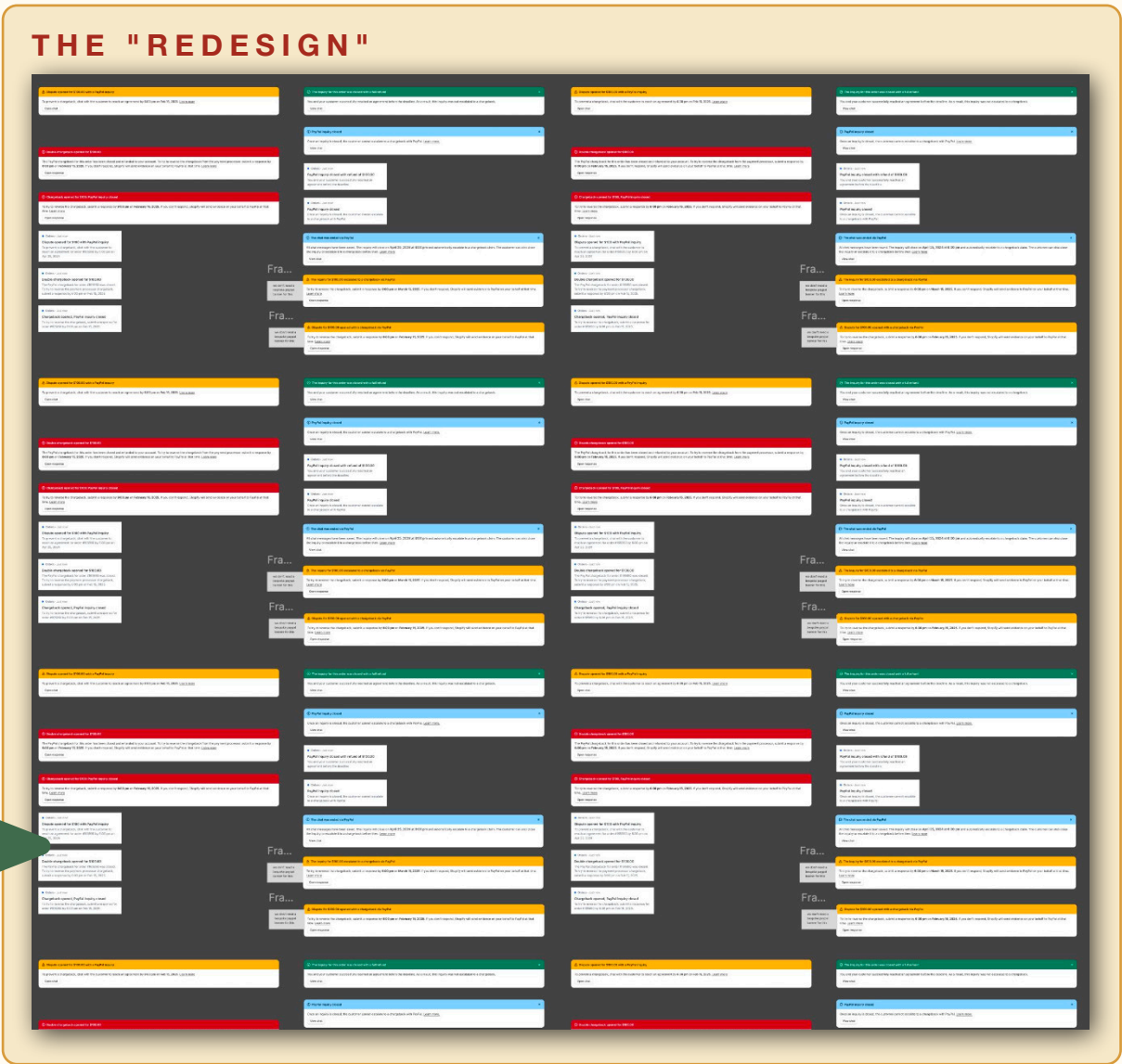
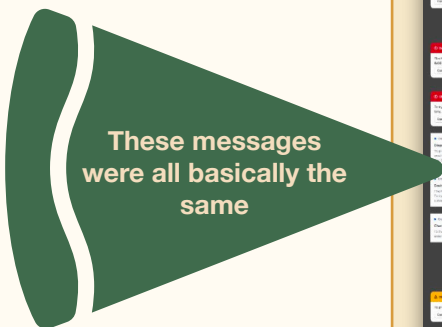
Reducing payout holds

End-to-end case study

CONTEXT

While working on a redesign of the payouts index, I was rewriting all of the payout errors when I started wondering WTF we were doing here.

Then I spent weeks investigating independently and lobbying to add an unplanned project to the roadmap.

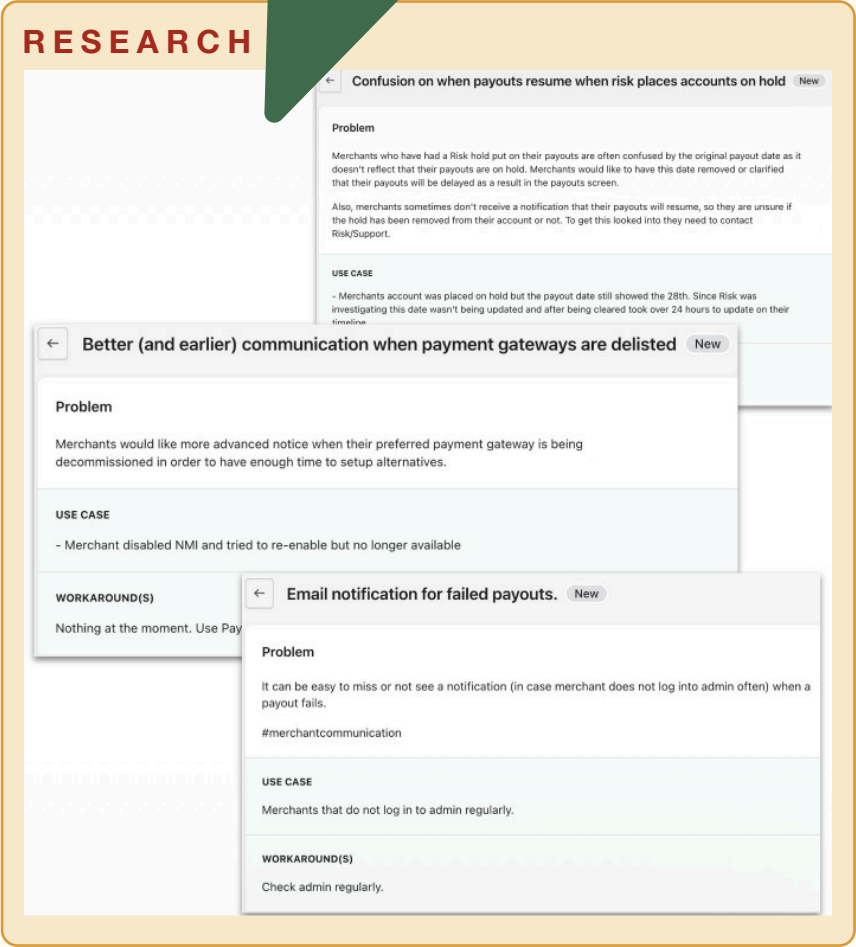
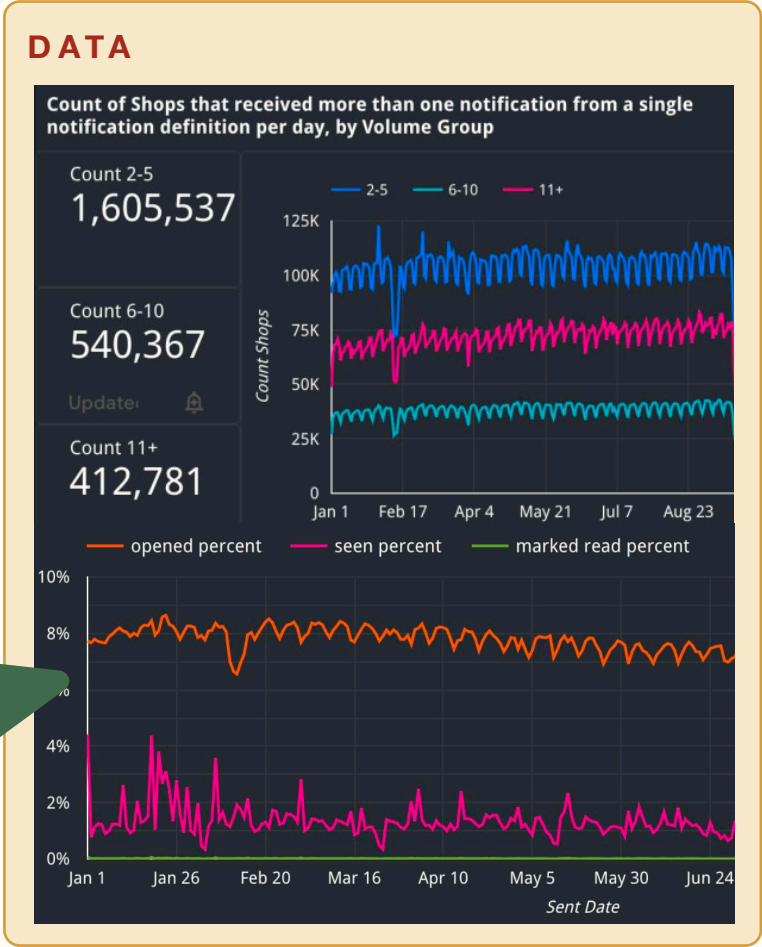


Reducing payout holds

PROBLEM

Merchants missed, ignored, or misread critical Shopify Payments messages. They discovered a problem only when the money they were expecting didn't arrive, resulting in support tickets or churn.

The most frequently sent notifications had the lowest open rates



Major content gap: no message on resolution

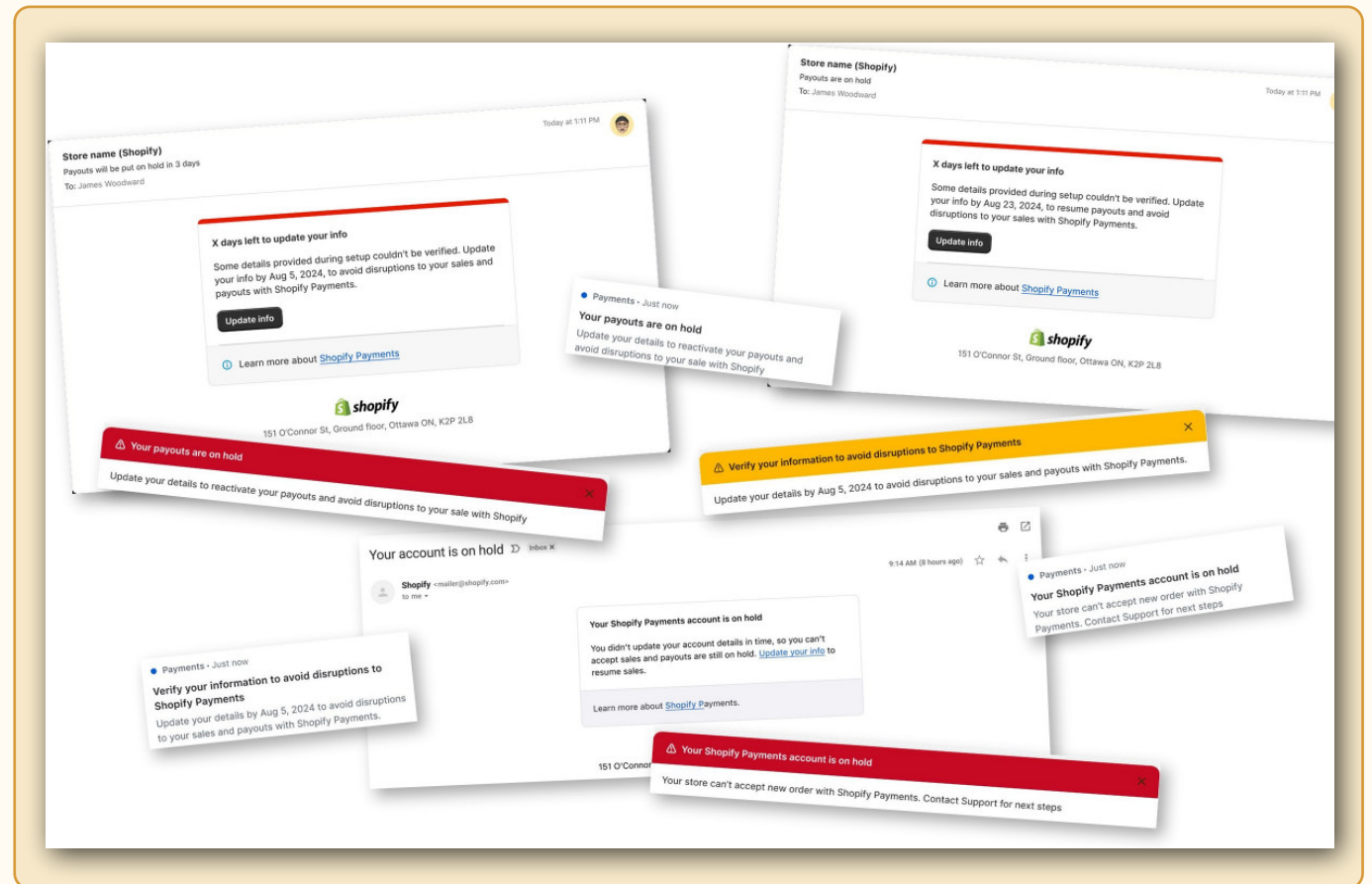
Reducing payout holds

CONSTRAINTS

There was no communication strategy at all. Every team sent its own messages. Simply sending more messages about a topic would worsen banner blindness and digital clutter.

DECISIONS

- Fewer, higher-signal messages instead of broader coverage
- A deliberately unexciting voice to build trust, not attention-grabbing tactics that might have lifted short-term open rates
- Acceptance that we couldn't deal with all messages everywhere at once



Reducing payout holds

A forward-looking playbook, not retroactive rewrites

PROPOSAL

Improve Shopify Payments communications so that...

- they're sent to the right people
- they're opened more often
- they arrive at the right time
- they address the right topics
- they contain clear expectations and CTAs

OUTCOMES

- Better metrics for the most impactful situations
- A playbook that became the model for communicating about remediation, bank account issues, and protective holds
- Strategic walkthroughs adapted to other payments scenarios, like fraud and government forms

THE FRAMEWORK



Reducing payout holds

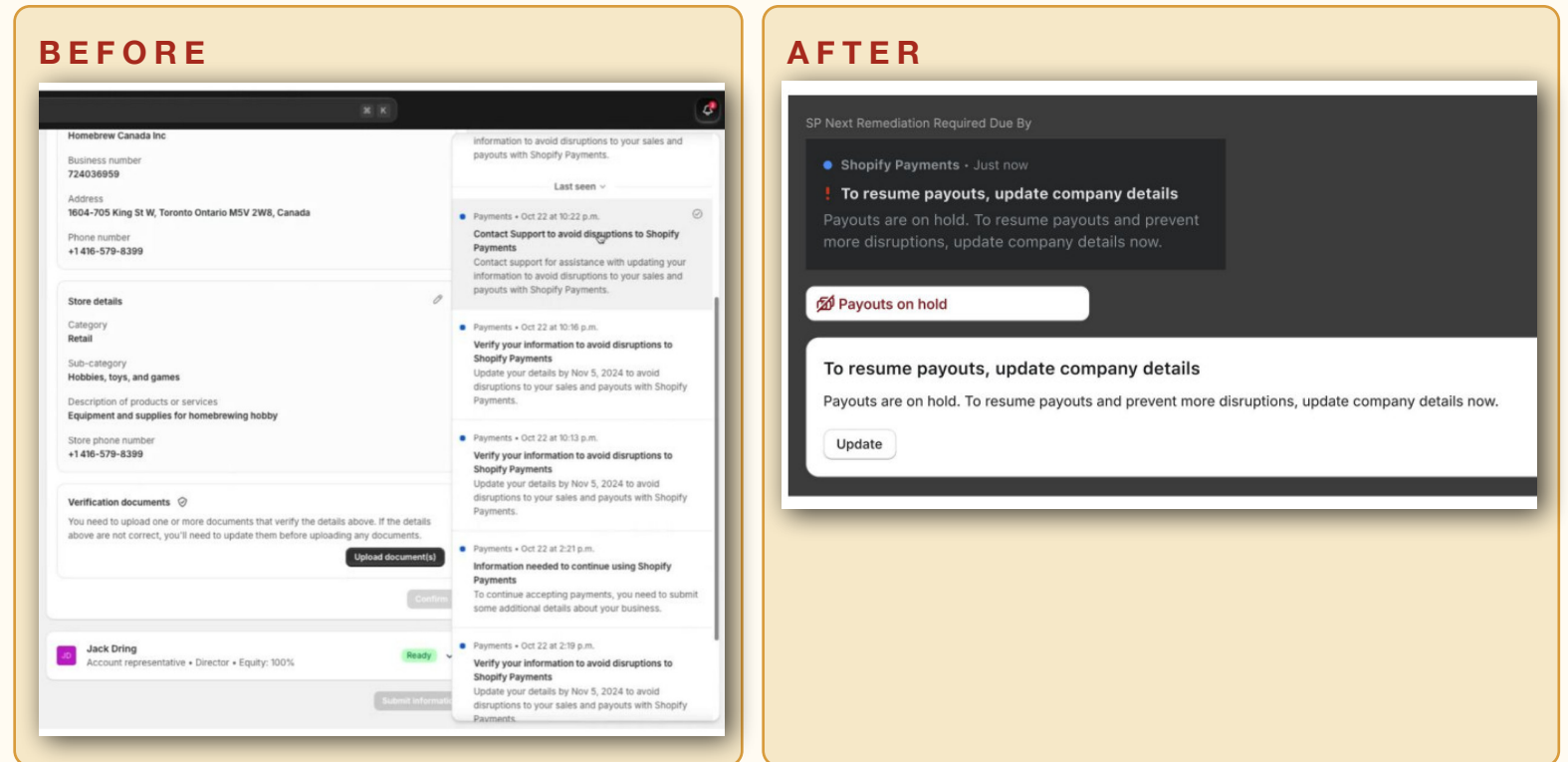
From disjointed to consistent

THE CHALLENGE

Shopify didn't have a cohesive approach to communications in general, much less for a specific scenario. Merchants got a stack of near-duplicate notifications.

THE SHIFT

Ensure uniformity of voice and approach across channels and scenarios: the same message, recognizably, wherever a merchant meets it.



Reducing payout holds

From unpredictable to specific

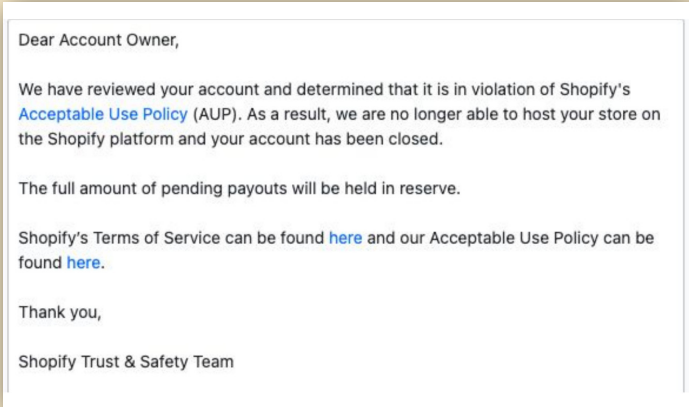
THE CHALLENGE

Shopify defaulted to email for communications about payouts on hold and failed to set expectations. It's legalese with no path forward.

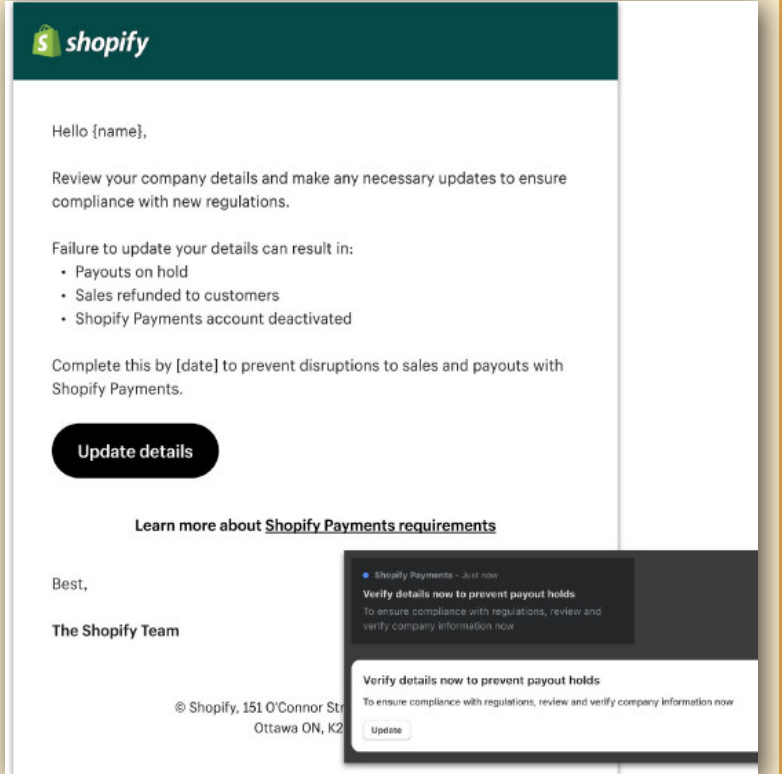
THE SHIFT

Share complexity about what is happening, why it's happening, and what a merchant needs to do to get payouts going again.

BEFORE



AFTER



Reducing payout holds

From hands-off to proactive

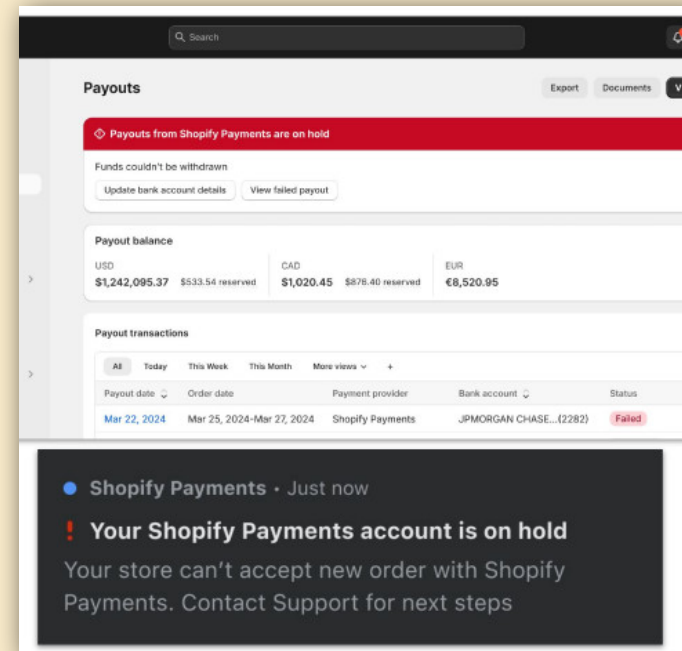
THE CHALLENGE

The right people weren't getting the right information at the right time, potentially cutting merchants off from a great deal of sales.

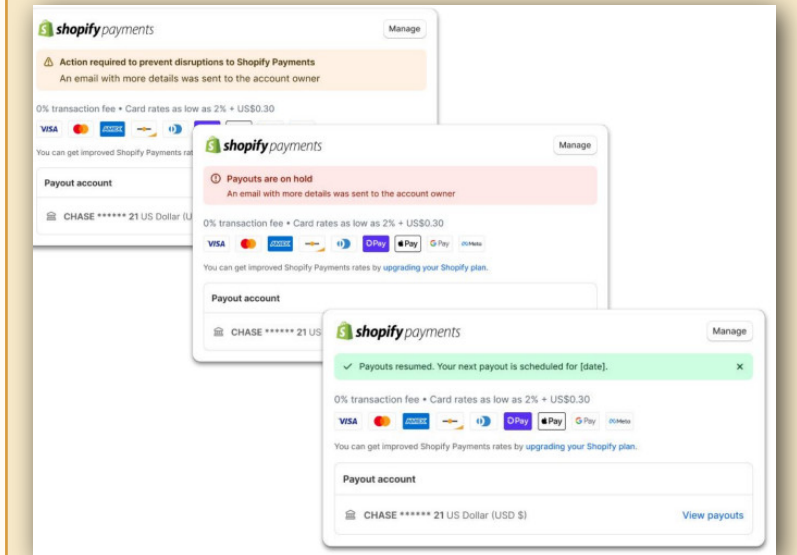
THE SHIFT

Encourage action from in-admin messaging, but make sure all users know a problem exists. That way, word can travel internally if a store owner can't be reached.

BEFORE



AFTER



Reducing payout holds

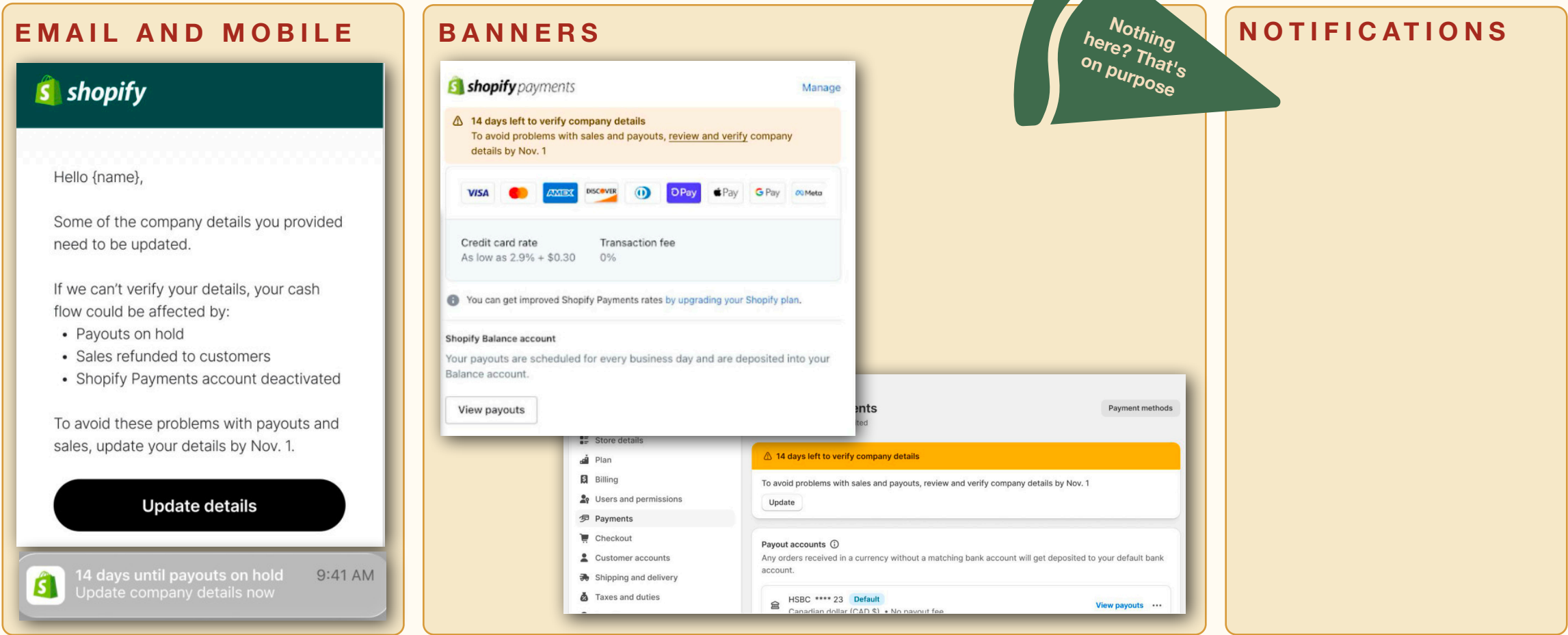
6 months after shipping new messages for payouts on hold due to remediation

THE RESULTS



New end-to-end experience

Introduction (initial reachout, T-10+ days)



New end-to-end experience

Approaching (dynamic reminders, T-7 days and T-1 day)

EMAIL AND MOBILE



Hello {name},

Provide additional information about your business by Nov. 1 to keep accepting sales and receiving payouts with Shopify Payments.

Update details

Learn more about [Shopify Payments requirements](#)



Payments on hold tomorrow

Update company details now

9:41 AM

BANNERS



Hem Canada

hem.ca

- Store details
- Plan
- Billing
- Users and permissions
- Payments
- Checkout
- Customer accounts
- Shipping and delivery
- Taxes and duties
- Locations
- Gift cards
- Markets

← Shopify Payments

for Alo Yoga Europe Limited

Payment methods

⚠ 7 days until payouts are on hold

To keep accepting sales and receiving payouts, update your company details by Nov. 1

Update

Payout accounts



Manage

⚠ 7 days until payouts are on hold

To keep accepting sales and receiving payouts, [update your company details](#) by Nov. 1

VISA

MasterCard

AMERICAN EXPRESS

DISCOVER

Interac

Digital Payments

Apple Pay

Google Pay

Meta Pay

Credit card rate

As low as 2.9% + \$0.30

Transaction fee

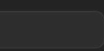
0%

⚠ Payouts on hold tomorrow

To avoid problems with sales and payouts, review and verify company details now

Update

NOTIFICATIONS



Next payout: \$23,456.24

Alerts

TODAY

Payments • Just now

7 days until payouts on hold

To keep accepting sales and receiving payouts, update your company details by Nov. 1

shopify

Search

⚠ Payouts go on hold tomorrow. To continue getting paid for your sales, [update company details](#).

Orders

Products

Customers

Sessions

210,123

2%

Total sales

\$155,213.12

4%

Payments • Just now

Update company details by tomorrow

Payouts will go on hold and your sales could be affected unless you act now

Payments.

SARAH M. SMART · WORD PERSON

New end-to-end experience

Impact (payouts are on hold, T-o days)

EMAIL AND MOBILE



Hello {name},

Your payouts are on hold. To resume payouts and keep selling, provide the additional business information required by your locality.

Update details

Learn more about
[Shopify Payments requirements](#)

Best,

The Shopify Team



Payouts are on hold

Update company details to resume

9:41 AM

BANNERS

← Shopify Payments

Payment methods

for Alo Yoga Europe Limited

ⓘ Payouts are on hold

To resume payouts and continue accepting sales, update company details now

Update

Payout accounts ⓘ

Any orders received in a currency without a matching bank account will get deposited to your default bank account.

☐ Payouts are on hold

To resume payouts and continue accepting sales, [update company details now](#)

0% transaction fee • Card rates as low as 2% + US\$0.30

VISA



AMEX





Pay

Apple Pay

Google Pay

Meta

You can get improved Shopify Payments rates by [upgrading your Shopify plan](#).

Payout account

NOTIFICATIONS

shopify

Search

◇ Payouts are on hold. To resume getting paid for your sales, [update company details](#).

Orders

Products

Customers

Sessions

210,123

▲ 2%

Total sa

\$155,21

Alerts

TODAY

● Payments • Just now

Resume payouts and keep selling

Payouts are on hold. Update company details now.

disruptions to your sales and payouts with Shopify Payments.

Capital • Just now

Your request for Shopify Capital is on hold

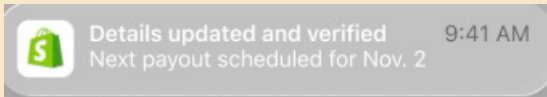
To keep your business growing, submit a request for capital.

New end-to-end experience

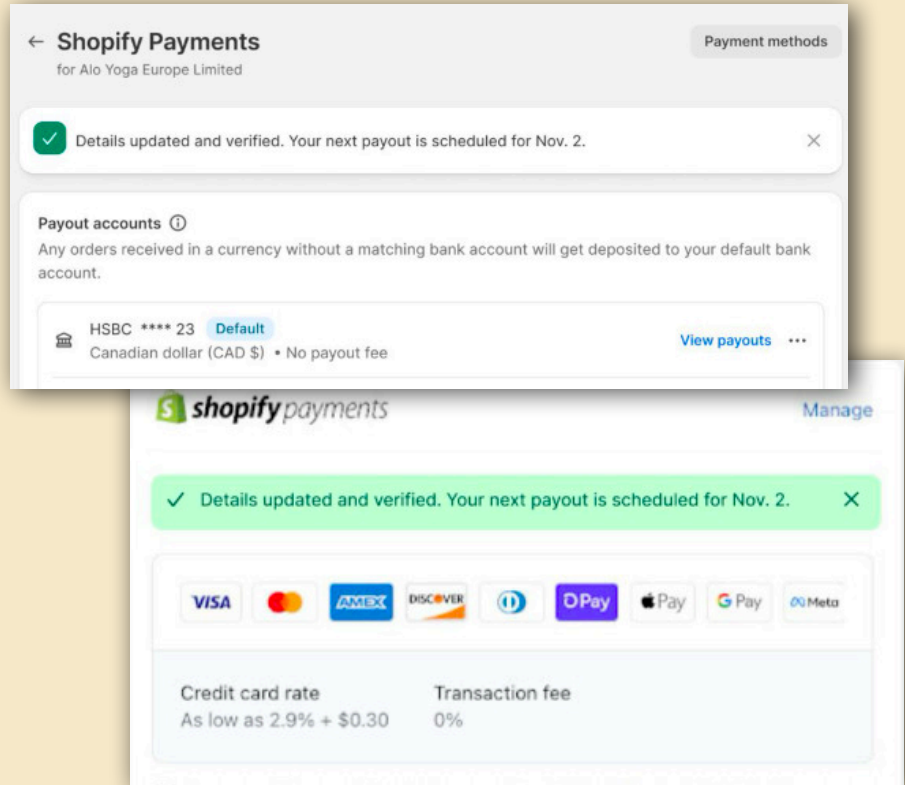
Resolution (payouts are resumed/continued, anytime after successful action)

Confirmation
doesn't
require
overload

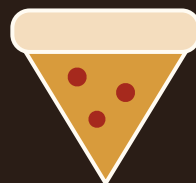
EMAIL AND MOBILE



BANNERS



NOTIFICATIONS



NOW TAKING ORDERS

Thank you!

sarahmsmart@gmail.com ♦ [linkedin.com/sarahmariesmart](https://www.linkedin.com/sarahmariesmart)